

ISS 2440: Introduction to Philosophy, Politics, Economics, and Law

University of Florida · Hamilton School for Classical and Civic Education

Fall 2026

Sections PE03 (#27798) & PE04 (#27799) · Mondays, Wednesdays, Fridays

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Office hours. Wednesdays, 8:30–11:30 AM, and by appointment.

Meeting times.

PE03 (#27798): MWF 11:45 AM – 12:35 PM

PE04 (#27799): MWF 12:50 – 1:40 PM

Room. [TBD] **Credits.** 3

Modality. 100% in person

1. Course Description

This course introduces the core concepts, methods, and debates that arise where philosophy, politics, economics, and law meet. Rather than surveying four disciplines in isolation, we build a single analytical toolkit and put it to work on enduring questions. We begin with the *concepts* that underlie all of political economy — competing visions of human nature, the economic way of thinking, the division of labor, and property rights. We then ask why the state exists at all, moving from *anarchy and the origins of the state* to *politics, constitutions, and elections*, and finally to the great modern argument over *capitalism and its critics*. Throughout, the aim is to help you reason carefully about social problems — to see the unseen, to weigh trade-offs, and to judge institutions by their incentives and consequences rather than their intentions. The course provides a foundation for further work in the PPEL major and minor.

2. Course Objectives

By the end of the course, you should be able to:

1. Identify the central questions and debates at the intersection of philosophy, politics, economics, and law.
2. Use core tools of analysis — rational choice, opportunity cost, the price system, property rights, game theory, collective action, and public choice — to reason about social and political problems.
3. Apply these tools to evaluate contemporary issues of policy, justice, and institutional design, distinguishing normative from positive claims.
4. Read difficult primary texts closely and discuss them with precision, charity, and rigor.

3. Required Materials

There is no textbook to purchase. All required readings are provided as PDFs on the course **Canvas** site, organized by week under “Modules.” You are expected to arrive at each class having completed the reading assigned for that day. A small number of readings may be adjusted during the term; any changes will be posted on Canvas with ample notice.

4. Graded Work

Your grade is composed of the following:

Component	Weight
Reading quizzes (lowest 3 dropped)	20%
Participation	25%
AI Reading Dialogues ($\times 4$, lowest dropped)	10%
Midterm 1	15%
Midterm 2	15%
Final exam	15%
Total	100%

Reading quizzes — 20%

A short quiz is given at the *start* of class on most weeks (roughly twelve over the term), covering the reading assigned for that day. Quizzes are closed-book and closed-note, with a few multiple-choice or short-answer questions designed to reward students who have done the reading. When a quiz includes short-answer questions, you will be able to choose among at least two. **Your three lowest quiz scores are dropped** — this automatically covers ordinary absences, illness, and off days, so there are no make-up quizzes. Quiz days are marked in the schedule below.

Participation — 25%

Participation is graded generously. The standard is good-faith engagement, not eloquence: come to class having done the reading, contribute honestly, and listen well to your classmates. Students who attend consistently and take part in good faith should expect full or near-full credit. See the participation rubric in §7. Attendance contributes to this component: you may miss **three** classes for any reason with no penalty; beyond the third, each unexcused absence reduces the participation grade (documented excused absences and religious-observance absences do not count against you, per UF policy). Phones and laptops should be put away during class unless I ask you to use them.

AI Reading Dialogues ($\times 4$) — 10%

Four times during the term you will hold a substantive *dialogue* with an AI model (**Claude** or **ChatGPT**, your choice) about an assigned reading, and submit it on Canvas. The point is not to have the AI summarize the text for you — it is to practice asking sharp, well-informed questions and to interrogate the answers you get.

What to do.

1. Upload or paste the assigned reading into the model.
2. Conduct a genuine back-and-forth: ask questions about the argument, press on weak points, request clarification, propose counter-examples, and connect the text to course concepts.
3. Submit (a) the **full transcript** of the conversation (a PDF export or a share link), and (b) a **150–250 word cover note** reflecting on what you learned, where the model was wrong, incomplete, or misleading, and what you would ask next.

How it is graded. You are graded on the quality of *your* side of the conversation (see the rubric

in §7). Detailed questions that quote or reference specific passages and arguments — clear evidence that you read the text — score highly. Generic prompts (“summarize this,” “what are the main points?”) score low. Catching a mistake or weak claim in the model’s answer, and saying why, is rewarded. Your lowest of the four dialogues is dropped, so the three highest count, each an equal share of the 10%. Due dates are in the schedule.

Exams — Midterm 1 (15%), Midterm 2 (15%), Final (15%)

There are two in-class midterms and a final exam, **equally weighted**. Each exam is **non-cumulative** and covers one block of the course:

- **Midterm 1** (Mon Sep 14) — Part I: Concepts for PPEL.
- **Midterm 2** (Mon Oct 26) — Parts II–III: Anarchy & the State; Politics, Constitutions & Elections.
- **Final** (Dec 5–11) — Part IV & the Week 15 debate.

Exams combine multiple-choice, short-answer, and a short essay. The final is held during the university final-exam period (Dec. 5–11) at the time assigned by the Registrar.

5. Weekly Schedule

All readings will be posted on the course Canvas site; arrive having completed the reading assigned for each week. Specific readings are finalized before the term begins and announced on Canvas. Dates with no class are noted.

Week	Topic	Assessments
Part I — Concepts for PPEL		
Wk 1 Aug 21 (Fri)	Two visions of human nature: the constrained and the unconstrained vision (<i>course introduction</i>). <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	
Wk 2 Aug 24–28	The economic way of thinking. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 1: Fri Aug 28
Wk 3 Aug 31–Sep 4	The division of labor and the Ricardian law of association. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 2: Fri Sep 4
Wk 4 Sep 9–11 (no class Mon Sep 7, Labor Day)	Property rights. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 3: Fri Sep 11
Part II — Anarchy and the State		
Wk 5 Sep 14–18	Anarchy I: the state of nature & introduction to game theory. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Midterm 1: Mon Sep 14 AI Dialogue 1 due: Fri Sep 18
Wk 6 Sep 21–25	Anarchy II: is anarchy so bad? <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 4: Fri Sep 25
Wk 7 Sep 28–Oct 2	The limits of anarchy and the origins of the state. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 5: Fri Oct 2

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Week	Topic	Assessments
Part III — Politics, Constitutions, and Elections		
Wk 8 Oct 5–7 (no class Fri Oct 9, Homecoming)	The general will and the paradoxes of voting. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 6: Wed Oct 7
Wk 9 Oct 12–16	Constitutional choice. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 7: Fri Oct 16 AI Dialogue 2 due: Fri Oct 16
Wk 10 Oct 19–23	The median voter theorem and democratic failures. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 8: Fri Oct 23
Part IV — Capitalism and its Critics		
Wk 11 Oct 26–30	Marx and the socialist critique I. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Midterm 2: Mon Oct 26 AI Dialogue 3 due: Fri Oct 30
Wk 12 Nov 2–6	Marx and the socialist critique II. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 9: Fri Nov 6
Wk 13 Nov 9–13 (no class Wed Nov 11, Veterans Day)	Entrepreneurship, central planning, and the use of knowledge in society. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 10: Fri Nov 13 AI Dialogue 4 due: Fri Nov 13
Wk 14 Nov 16–18 (no class Fri Nov 20, SEA conference)	Social justice. <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 11: Wed Nov 18
<i>Thanksgiving break — Nov 23–27: no class</i>		
Part V — A Debate in Applied PPEL		
Wk 15 Nov 30–Dec 2	A current debate — the class chooses one: (a) Is there a duty to vote? (b) A market for organs? (c) A market for citizenship? <i>Read:</i> posted on Canvas.	Quiz 12: Mon Nov 30
Finals Dec 5–11	Final exam — Part IV & the Week 15 debate, at the Registrar-assigned time.	Final exam

6. Grading Scale

Final letter grades follow the standard UF scale. For how grade points are assigned, see <https://catalog.ufl.edu/UGRD/academic-regulations/grades-grading-policies/>.

A	94–100%	C	74–76%
A–	90–93%	C–	70–73%
B+	87–89%	D+	67–69%
B	84–86%	D	64–66%
B–	80–83%	D–	60–63%
C+	77–79%	E	below 60%

7. Rubrics

Participation (graded generously)

A (90–100)	Comes to class prepared, having done the reading; contributes in good faith and engages others' ideas respectfully. Consistent attendance.
B (80–89)	Generally prepared and present; participates, though less consistently, or listens more than contributes.
C (70–79)	Attends but is rarely prepared or rarely participates.
D–E (below 70)	Frequently absent and unprepared; does not participate.

AI Reading Dialogue

Each dialogue is scored on four criteria (equal weight):

Close reading	Questions and comments refer to specific passages, arguments, or examples in the text — clear evidence the reading was done.
Quality of questioning	Questions are sharp, build on one another, and push beyond surface summary toward the argument's assumptions, mechanisms, and implications.
Critical evaluation	The student tests the model's answers — spotting errors, vague or unsupported claims, and gaps — and explains why.
Synthesis & reflection	The cover note connects the reading to course concepts and honestly assesses what the exchange did and did not clarify.

Generic prompts (e.g. “summarize this”) and transcripts that show no evidence of having read the text receive low marks regardless of length.

Examination rubric: essays and short answers

	Completeness	Analysis	Evidence	Writing
A (90–100)	Shows a thorough understanding of the question. Addresses all aspects of the question completely.	Analyses, evaluates, compares and/or contrasts issues and events with depth.	Incorporates pertinent and detailed information from both class discussions and assigned readings.	Presents all information clearly and concisely, in an organized manner.
B (80–89)	Presents a general understanding of the question. Completely addresses most aspects of the question, or addresses all aspects incompletely.	Analyses or evaluates issues and events, but not in any depth.	Includes relevant facts, examples and details but does not support all aspects of the task evenly.	Presents information fairly and evenly, and may have minor organization problems.
C (70–79)	Shows a limited understanding of the question. Does not address most aspects of the question.	Lacks analysis or evaluation of the issues and events beyond stating accurate, relevant facts.	Includes relevant facts and details, but omits concrete examples, includes inaccurate information, and/or does not support all aspects of the task.	Lacks focus, somewhat interfering with comprehension.
D (60–69)	Fails fully to answer the specific central question.	Lacks analysis or evaluation of the issues and events beyond stating vague, irrelevant, and/or inaccurate facts.	Does not incorporate information from pertinent class discussion and/or assigned readings.	Organizational problems prevent comprehension.
E (below 60)	Does not answer the specific central question.	Lacks analysis or evaluation of the issues and events.	Does not adduce any evidence.	Incomprehensible organization and prose.

8. Course Policies

Use of AI

This course is deliberately **AI-forward**. You are encouraged to use AI tools (such as Claude or ChatGPT) to study, brainstorm, test your understanding, and draft — and AI is a required, graded part of the AI Reading Dialogues. Two limits apply:

- **Closed-book assessments.** Reading quizzes and all three exams are completed without AI or any other aid. Using AI on these is a violation of academic integrity.
- **Disclosure.** On written work other than the dialogues (where AI use is the assignment itself), briefly note where and how you used AI. AI is a tool to think with, not a substitute for your own thinking; you are responsible for the accuracy of anything you submit, including AI errors.

Attendance and late work

Attendance is expected. Three absences are free of penalty (see Participation); documented excused absences and religious-observance absences follow UF policy and are not counted against you. There are no make-up quizzes (the three-lowest-dropped policy covers absences). Make-up exams are

granted only for documented, university-approved reasons; contact me as early as possible.

University policies

All standard university policies — academic honesty, accommodations for students with disabilities, in-class recording, evaluations, and student resources — apply to this course and are available at <https://go.ufl.edu/syllabuspolicies>. Students requesting accommodations should register with the Disability Resource Center and share their accommodation letter with me early in the term. If you are struggling, academically or otherwise, please reach out — I am glad to help, and UF has strong support resources.

This syllabus is subject to minor changes; any updates will be announced in class and posted on Canvas.